USER MANUAL

TB Compressor

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Overview

Balances uneven volume and shapes the punch, smoothness, and density of a sound.

What this plug-in solves

Dynamic sources often need both level control and purposeful tone. A transparent compressor may control peaks but leave the source uninspiring; a colored compressor may add energy but obscure the dynamics decision. TB Compressor separates detection, gain reduction, sidechain focus, and saturation so each part can be set deliberately.

What you can expect

- Transparent leveling or assertive peak control
- Frequency-focused detector behavior
- Linked stereo image stability
- Optional harmonic color before final level trim

How it works

TB Compressor follows the changing loudness of the source and turns down the parts that rise beyond the chosen working point. Peak detection concentrates on short spikes, while RMS detection follows the average body of the sound, so the same plug-in can protect transients or perform smoother musical leveling.

Attack and Release shape how the front and body of each sound survive the gain reduction. Sidechain filters decide what the detector pays attention to, Stereo Link keeps the image steady, and the saturation stage can add density after the dynamics are under control. Set the compression first, then add color and match the output loudness.

Quick start

1. Set Input, Makeup, and Output to unity and disable Saturation.
2. Choose Peak or RMS detection.
3. Lower Threshold until gain reduction reaches the intended range.

4. Set Ratio and Knee for control character.
5. Tune Attack and Release in the context of the song.
6. Use sidechain filtering if lows or highs trigger too strongly.
7. Add saturation last and level-match with Output.

Interface and key sections

This is a direct capture of the current plug-in interface. Use the visible labels to locate the areas and controls explained below.

Peak and RMS detection

Peak mode reacts to instantaneous excursions and is suited to drums and protection. RMS mode follows average energy and is often smoother for vocals, bass, and buses.

Threshold, Ratio, and Knee

Threshold defines where compression begins, Ratio controls how strongly level above threshold is restrained, and Knee softens the transition. A wide knee is smoother; a narrow knee is more decisive.

Attack, Release, and Lookahead

Attack preserves or suppresses the front of a sound, Release determines recovery, and Lookahead allows earlier peak control at the cost of latency. Very short attack and release values can sound dense or distorted by design.

Sidechain filters

Low Cut prevents sub-bass from dominating detection. High Cut can reduce detector sensitivity to bright transients. These filters affect the detector, not the audible program path.

Stereo Link

Stereo Link applies a shared dynamics decision so the image does not tilt when one channel peaks. Disable only for intentionally independent channel movement.

Saturation system

Enable Saturation, select Clean, Soft, Hard, Punch, Warm, or Tape, then use Drive and Mix. The separate Circuit Model choices change response character. Oversampling reduces aliasing at higher CPU and latency cost.

Gain staging

Input changes how hard the detector and color stages are driven. Makeup restores intentional level after reduction; Output is the final trim. Compare at matched loudness.

Controllable properties

The guide uses the names shown on the plug-in panel. Each explanation describes the audible result, a useful way to approach the control, and an important interaction to listen for.

Control	What it does and when to use it
Attack	Sets how quickly the effect reacts when a sound begins. Faster values control the front; slower values keep more punch. Judge this control while the source repeats in the full arrangement. The right timing should support the groove without making the sound feel detached.
Bypass	Turns the complete effect off or on for a direct before-and-after comparison. Compare with bypass at a similar loudness. If the effect creates a tail, let that tail settle before judging the difference.
Input	Sets how loud the sound enters the plug-in. Raise it for a stronger response or lower it for more headroom. Match the final loudness before deciding whether the processing sounds better. Extra level can make almost any setting seem more impressive.
Knee	Softens the point where compression begins. Higher values sound gentler and less obvious. Move it gradually and listen for the point where the intended result becomes clear without introducing a new problem elsewhere.
Lookahead	Helps catch sudden peaks more smoothly. Higher values can feel slightly less immediate. Judge this control while the source repeats in the full arrangement. The right timing should support the groove without making the sound feel detached.
Makeup	Restores level after compression has made the sound quieter. Match the final loudness before deciding whether the processing sounds better. Extra level can make almost any setting seem more impressive.
Output	Sets the final listening level after processing. Match the final loudness before deciding whether the processing sounds better. Extra level can make almost any setting seem more impressive.
Oversampling	Makes heavy distortion or limiting sound cleaner at the cost of more CPU use. Move it gradually and listen for the point where the intended result becomes clear without introducing a new problem elsewhere.

Control	What it does and when to use it
Program	Loads a factory starting point. Adjust the controls afterward to fit the current sound. Use a preset as a direction, not a finished answer. Change one section at a time so it is clear which adjustment improves the source.
Ratio	Sets how strongly level is controlled after it crosses the threshold. Move it gradually and listen for the point where the intended result becomes clear without introducing a new problem elsewhere.
Release	Sets how quickly the effect relaxes after the sound becomes quieter. Set it in relation to the rhythm and the space between events. Listen for pumping, gaps, or a tail that covers the next sound.
RMS	Changes the listening behavior from fast peak control to smoother average-level control. Move it gradually and listen for the point where the intended result becomes clear without introducing a new problem elsewhere.
Saturation	Chooses the harmonic character added after compression. Level-match the result and listen for lost transients or harsh buildup. More color is useful only while the source still keeps its role in the mix.
Saturation Drive	Sets how strongly the saturation section is pushed. Level-match the result and listen for lost transients or harsh buildup. More color is useful only while the source still keeps its role in the mix.
Saturation Enabled	Turns the harmonic color section on or off. Level-match the result and listen for lost transients or harsh buildup. More color is useful only while the source still keeps its role in the mix.
Saturation Mix	Blends the added harmonic color with the cleaner compressed sound. Turn the processed sound up temporarily to learn its character, then return to the mix and keep only the amount that supports the source.
Saturator Circuit Model	Chooses the overall response and color of the saturation section. Compare the available characters on the same short passage. Choose by the musical result rather than by the name of the mode.
Sidechain High Cut	Removes high frequencies from the current sound or effect layer. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.

Control	What it does and when to use it
Sidechain Low Cut	Removes low frequencies from the current sound or effect layer. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.
Stereo Link	Makes both channels react together so the stereo image does not lean to one side. Move it gradually and listen for the point where the intended result becomes clear without introducing a new problem elsewhere.
Threshold	Sets how loud the sound must be before the current control begins working. Move it until the section reacts too often, then back away until it follows only the events you actually want to control.

Practical uses

Vocal leveling

- Enable RMS.
- Use a moderate ratio and soft knee.
- Set Attack long enough to keep consonants clear.
- Use a medium release that returns between phrases.
- Apply light Warm or Tape saturation in parallel.

Expected result: The vocal stays forward and even without losing articulation.

Drum punch

- Use Peak detection.
- Set a slower attack to pass the initial hit.
- Set release to recover before the next beat.
- Use Punch saturation and oversampling if additional density is needed.

Expected result: Transients remain defined while the body becomes denser and more controlled.

Sidechain ducking

- Route the key signal to the external sidechain bus.
- Use sidechain filters to isolate the useful trigger range.
- Choose fast attack and tempo-appropriate release.
- Keep Stereo Link enabled for stable imaging.

Expected result: The target track moves out of the way predictably when the key signal arrives.

Common pitfalls

Lookahead and oversampling can change latency. Use the lighter quality setting while recording and reserve the heavier option for playback or export. Change latency-related modes while playback is stopped.

Saturation Mix is not a substitute for compression Makeup. Return the strongest control toward neutral, compare with bypass at a similar loudness, and add the processing back one section at a time.

Heavy unlinked compression can move the stereo image. Reduce width or movement and check the result in mono as well as stereo. Preserve the original spatial cues when they are important to the recording.